



A different approach

Bold coaches follow the adaptation mode. They might design 14-day microcycles, 30-day mesocycles, or 15-session blocks, however long it takes, to create the physiological changes they're seeking.

This is particularly important for players recovering from serious injury or in rehabilitation.

I've worked with coaches who build progression on actual adaptation markers — skill and technique attributes, RPE (Rate of Perceived Exertion), training outcomes, recovery indicators — rather than dates on a calendar. When their athletes are ready biologically, they progress. When they're not, they don't, at any cost.

A strength and conditioning coach from a professional multi-sport setup once told me: "I stopped losing athletes to overtraining injuries when I stopped caring about fitting training into

weeks and started caring about fitting training into their individual recovery windows." The results, he said, were consistently positive.

Fit the athlete to a bespoke, individual process, not the timeline designed for someone else. Every athlete responds differently to the same stimulus.

Our job isn't to make athletes fit into our periodisation model. Rather, it's to make our model fit around the athlete's capacity to adapt and recover.

A professional should ask: "Is this athlete truly ready for progression, or am I advancing them just because my calendar says I should. Am I ticking the right boxes for the wrong reasons?" The honest answer might change everything about how training and progression can be planned.

Practical protocols

1. Adaptation evaluation:

Before progressing to the next training cycle, evaluate three key

Not in the same boat: An athlete juggling school and exams, or any other stress, cannot recover at the same rate as one whose life is stable and stress-free. GETTYIMAGES

markers in each athlete — skill or technique quality under fatigue, energy levels during warm-up, and enthusiasm for training — rather than automatically advancing because 14 days have passed.

2. Tractable sequence tryout:

Design your next training block as a 21-day cycle instead of the traditional seven-day week, and observe whether athletes demonstrate better adaptation and fewer breakdown indicators.

3. Individual recovery interfaces:

Track your top two or three athletes' actual recovery patterns over a 3-4-week period. Note when they genuinely seem ready to progress versus when the calendar says they should, and fine-tune future planning accordingly.